Meeting Cost & ROI Method Guide

Price every recurring meeting, rank them by real annual cost, and cancel the ones that produce no decision.

1. What this guide is for

This guide turns meeting time into a visible annual cost and, more importantly, into a decision. It is the companion to the B12-004 workbook, which does the arithmetic for you. Read this once, then work through the workbook sheet by sheet. The goal is not an auditable payroll report - it is a management tool that answers one uncomfortable question: does this recurring meeting still earn its place on the calendar?

Meetings almost never appear as a line item. The spend hides inside payroll, which is exactly why it is easy to underestimate and hard to cut. A recurring meeting that felt free in week one becomes a six-figure commitment over a year across a whole team. The method below makes that number visible and comparable.

2. Step one - price a meeting honestly

Most people price a meeting with a raw salary guess and stop there. That undercounts. The honest figure is the fully-loaded hourly rate: **loaded rate = annual salary / 2080 hours x (1 + employer surcharge)**. The 2080 assumes a standard full-time year. The surcharge covers tax, benefits, pension, equipment and overhead, and it is the step people skip - which undercounts meeting cost by roughly 17% to 26%.

Use a surcharge of about **20% for EU teams** and about **35% for US teams** as a working default. Worked derivation: a $90,000 salary is $43.27/hour at 2080 hours; add a 30% surcharge and the loaded rate is $56.25/hour, not $43.27. A six-person weekly hour that looked like $260 is really $337. Nobody needs the exact figure - they need a number they cannot wave away.

- **Blended vs per-role:** one blended rate is fast and fine for a small, similar team. If a leadership meeting and a team huddle share a headcount but not a pay band, use per-role rates - the blended rate hides the difference.
- **Do not over-engineer:** round to the nearest dollar. The decision you make from $56/hr and $57/hr is identical.
- **Write it down once:** put your default rate on the Setup sheet so every row uses the same assumption.

3. Step two - log every recurring meeting

Recurring meetings are where the money quietly compounds: they repeat by default and rarely get removed. For each one, capture the attendee count, the loaded rate, the length in hours, how many times it runs per week, and how many real decisions it produces. Do not skip the unglamorous ones - the daily standup and the weekly round-robin are usually the biggest annual lines precisely because nobody thinks of them as expensive.

- Use real attendee counts, not ideal ones. If eight people accept the invite, it is an eight-person meeting.

- Record the length as scheduled, then decide separately whether it should be shorter.
- If a meeting only sometimes produces a decision, average it honestly - a standup that decides once a week is '0.2 decisions per meeting', not '1'.

4. Step three - ask the one question

For every recurring meeting, ask the single question that reframes the cost: **what decision does this meeting exist to make?** If the answer is 'none - it is an update', it is a status meeting, and status belongs in a document or a chat thread. That one question separates meetings that earn their cost from meetings that merely feel productive. An expensive meeting that makes decisions is fine. A cheap meeting that decides nothing is still waste - and there are usually far more of them than anyone expects.

5. Step four - cost per decision

Cost per decision = (attendees x loaded rate x hours) / decisions produced. This is the figure worth arguing about, and it is the one number that turns a cost people dismiss into a cost they have to answer for. A meeting that costs $600 and decides three things is $200 per decision. A meeting that costs $200 and decides nothing is infinite. The workbook computes cost per decision for every row and flags any meeting that crosses the threshold you set on the Setup sheet, so the worst offenders surface on their own.

6. Step five - annualise

A weekly meeting is not a weekly cost - it is that cost multiplied by your working weeks. At 46 working weeks, a $450/week meeting is about $20,700/year. Multiply the meeting across a team and the numbers get serious fast: a recurring hour with five people is a five-figure annual commitment; with twelve, six figures. Annualising is what makes the review happen, because nobody argues about a number that small at weekly scale.

7. Step six - the quarterly kill review

Set a recurring review or the cost quietly returns. Once a quarter, open the workbook's Dashboard, sort the logged meetings by annual cost, and apply three verdicts: keep, shorten, or kill. Kill every meeting that produced no decision. Shorten the meetings whose length cannot be justified. Protect the survivors with a clear owner, a stated decision, and a deadline.

- ■ Export the Dashboard and sort by annual cost
- ■ Kill meetings with zero decisions last quarter
- ■ Shorten meetings longer than their agenda needs
- ■ Set an end date on every surviving recurring meeting
- ■ Agree the date of the next review before the meeting ends

8. How to use the workbook

- **Setup:** set your default loaded hourly rate, working weeks per year, and the decision-value threshold. The optional helper derives a loaded rate from a salary plus surcharge if you prefer that

route.

- **MeetingLog:** one row per recurring meeting. Fill only the white cells - attendees, loaded rate, hours, times per week, and decisions per meeting. The blue cells compute cost and must not be overwritten. Yellow rows are examples - replace or delete them.
- **Dashboard:** totals, monthly and annual cost, total person-hours, the most expensive meeting, and the annual saving from cancelling every zero-decision meeting. Start your kill review here.
- **Rules:** the operating defaults. Re-read them before each quarterly review, because the defaults decay when nobody is watching.
- **README:** a one-screen recap of how the sheets fit together and what each output means.

9. Worked example - a team of seven

A team of seven, loaded at $65/hour. The daily standup: 7 x $65 x 0.25 hours x 5 days = $568.75/week, about $26,160/year at 46 weeks - for status that fits in a chat thread. Kill it, and keep a Monday 15-minute blocker review at $113.75/week. The biweekly planning meeting: 7 x $65 x 2 hours x 0.5 times/week = $455/week; shorten it to 90 minutes and it drops to $341.25/week. Two changes to one team's calendar recover roughly $26,000 a year of paid time - time that is now spent on work instead of on describing work.

10. Five mistakes that ruin the number

- **Skipping the surcharge:** pricing off raw salary undercounts by 17-26% and makes every meeting look cheaper than it is.
- **Using a blended rate for a mixed team:** it hides the senior-heavy meetings, which are usually the expensive ones.
- **Counting announced attendees, not accepting attendees:** optional attendees still cost money when they attend.
- **Forgetting that recurring means annual:** a weekly meeting is 46 times its weekly cost, every year, until someone ends it.
- **Reviewing once, then never again:** without a quarterly review, meetings creep back and the recovered time is lost.

11. Objections, answered

'Our meetings are valuable.' Then the cost per decision will be low and the workbook will say so - the method protects good meetings, it does not cap them. **'I do not have exact salaries.'** You do not need them; a defensible loaded rate and honest attendee counts are enough to find the worst offenders. **'We are remote, so meetings matter more.'** Remote makes async easier, not harder - status in a doc is cheaper than a call in every time zone. **'Nothing will change.'** The point is not to change the culture in one meeting; it is to make the cost visible once a quarter until cutting the obvious waste becomes routine.

12. What this is not

This is arithmetic on your own inputs. Loaded rates and decision counts are estimates you own, and the workbook only shows what your numbers imply - it promises no savings and no outcomes. It is not HR, legal, payroll or financial advice. Sample rows are fictional illustrations.